Nancy and I arrived in the Soviet Union on May 29, 1988. During a stopover in Finland, we learned that the Senate had overwhelmingly ratified the INF treaty after weeks of brinkmanship that made it uncertain Gorbachev and I could complete the ratification papers while I was in Moscow.

This was my first visit to the Soviet Union, but my fourth meeting with Gorbachev and perhaps the most memorable, partly because for the first time I also got to meet and shake hands with ordinary Soviet people.

At our first session alone, Gorbachev again expressed his desire for increased U.S.-Soviet trade. I was ready for him. I'd thought about what I was going to say when he brought up the issue: One reason we have trouble increasing trade with your country, I said, was that many members of Congress as well as many other Americans oppose it because of what they consider Soviet human rights abuses.

I brought up a thought that had been expressed to me in a letter from a recent immigrant to America: Americans, he said, come from every corner of the world, but once they are in America, they are assimilated in a way that is unique in the world. An immigrant can live in France, he said, but not become a Frenchman; he can live in Germany but not become a German; he can live in Japan but not become a Japanese; but anyone from any part of the world can come to America and become an American. "Our people have diverse backgrounds," I told Gorbachev, "but they are united when they see any people discriminated against simply because of their ethnic origin or religious belief." Then I raised an issue that had been on my mind for a long time: religious freedom in the Soviet Union. "This isn't something I'm suggesting we negotiate," I told him, "just an idea. I'm not trying to tell you how to run your country, but I realize you are probably concerned that if you allow too many of the Jews who want to emigrate from the Soviet Union to leave, there'll be a 'brain drain,' a loss of skilled